Historical Sources and Commodity Circulation in the Western Himalayan Salt Economy

2.1 Introduction

The movement of salt in the Western Himalayas involved connecting sites of production with pastoral communities, agricultural communities, market towns, and governmental institutions. These links involved journeys which were organised by making use of seasonal accessibility, transport animals, business partnerships, and permits to enter specific regions. The history of salt therefore goes beyond the extraction and trade of a product. It concerns the arrangements that made circulation possible and the changes that redirected goods, labour and income across the region.

The previous chapter established the theoretical and historiographical foundations for examining exchange, customary obligations and political intervention. This chapter turns to the historical record which serves to explore what historical records have to say about the nature and regulation of commodity circuits, and thus provide an evidential base for the computation process described in the next chapter. The hypothesis still remains open to scrutiny, and that is whether salt roads provided a framework for multi-commodity trade relations. The existence of salt trade alone does not settle that question.

Ladakh and Rupshu represent the geographic core of this research, whereas Garhwal, Mandi and Kinnaur are to be treated as comparative regions. It is in these areas that one finds various forms of circulation – the seasonal frontier trade, controlled production and changing dynamics between cross-border trade and survival. It is not assumed that there was an identical economic system throughout the Himalayas; rather, what is being examined is the way similar functions were performed in varying conditions.

What is being focused on is the twentieth century with prior treaties and descriptions being used as precedents. Within that century, colonial revenue arrangements must be distinguished from subsequent border restrictions and changes in transport. The chapter starts with assessing the documentary evidence and proceeds to exploring commodity circulation and political regulation. It ends with a discussion of the problem that arises from dispersed historical evidence and the usefulness of a relational approach. The technical procedures for building and evaluating that reconstruction remain the subject of the following chapter.

2.2 The Documentary Record and Its Limits

Historical sources are varied because those that created them had differing concerns. The district officer wanted information on production and revenue. The traveller documented places that he came across along his route. The survey of the village looked into households and

occupations. A treaty was a documentation of claims and obligations. These sources are made relevant when considered collectively through keeping in mind their perspectives. Considering these documents comparatively enables one to view the relationship that appears in one document from another perspective without considering each surviving source equally an observation.

Gazetteers provide a particularly important foundation. Their accounts gather geographical, economic and administrative information within the boundaries of a district or state. Walton's British Garhwal distinguishes commerce with Tibet, commerce with southern markets and trade within the district (Walton, 1910, p. 42). Such a classification is administrative in its nature, however, a commodity could pass through all these three classifications. This would mean that one must consider documents beyond the classifications made in the gazetteer in order to make sense of their circulation.

The Mandi gazetteer offers a different concentration of evidence. Its discussion of salt includes quarry management, labour, charges and the distribution of revenue between authorities (Emerson, 1920, pp. 160–164). Such detail enables the historian to analyse the mechanisms of administration. This also speaks to the concerns of the compiling institution: productivity, efficiency and revenue continue to receive consistent attention. Claims that workers were successful because of an adjustment should be understood as official analysis in light of the information provided on wages and obligations, not as a full understanding of the workers' experience.

Gazetteers can also contain several historical layers. The date of publication does not date every arrangement described. A volume may reproduce an earlier settlement report, recount a sequence of agreements, and then describe conditions at compilation. Separation is necessary, when a nineteenth century enactment is followed by a twentieth century assessment of its effects, before reconstitution can occur. If this is not done, the historical narrative would incorrectly be seen as one that covers two different administrative processes simultaneously.

Information arrangement in travel descriptions is unique. The description by Thomson of Thogji Chumo salt lake is part of a larger travel description covering his journey in Western Himalayas and Tibet (Thomson, 1852, Chapter VI, pp. 170-174). The travel route ensures that the observations are made in a travel context. This means that they offer details on the landscape and its accessibility. Finding a salt resource does not necessarily mean that it was the destination of its output, just like the description of a caravan did not imply the exchange processes of its goods.

Treaties document the terms on which authorities sought to structure their relations. The reproduced Tingmosgang Treaty is relevant to trading rights and political obligations, but a clause is a documented arrangement rather than consistent implementation of it. The translation and reproduction of the document are further mediations of the text. The administrative correspondence can provide insight into how the clause was interpreted, disputed or changed, though the complaint and the reply reflect localised positions. It is crucial to differentiate between proposals, commitments and practices in the interpretation of political power.

The surveys related to the 1961 Census also give a different perspective on the place. The survey of Kanum involves a re-visit in October 1964. Its account brings named traders, household resources and occupational changes into view (Singh, 1966a, Appendix XI, pp. 112–115). It is particularly useful when general descriptions of decreased trading in frontier areas do not specify the impacts on individual families. Individual dates have to be given to the observations of the survey; materials gathered on a return visit should not necessarily be given the date of the census mentioned in the title of the series.

The surveys themselves are infused with a language of development, which needs to be questioned. In Nachar, the road and state institutions are portrayed as elements of change which have transformed a previously distant village, while recognising that it was subject to previous trips out of season and visits to Lavi (Singh, 1966b, p. 54). Being distant from a motor road does not imply lack of outside relations. A historian can use the description of new linkages provided in the report while rejecting the story that significant contacts had begun only with the arrival of modern transportation.

Ethnographic research supplies evidence about practices and interpretations that official accounts often compress. Ahmed’s study of Rupshu combines observation with recollections of earlier trade, making it necessary to distinguish what participants remembered from what the researcher witnessed (Ahmed, 1999). Such sources are helpful in studying the perceptions people had regarding changes in access and livelihood. They should never be taken as a perpetual list of customs. An institution observed late in the twentieth century could have been carrying an old practice, modifying it, or adapting to a recent change.

It is clear that such sources are able to allow comparison on various scales without giving rise to a continuous statistical database. Trade figures, individual accounts and narratives of a fair are things which cannot be simply added up. There is a difference in activities they represent. The repetition in a statement may originate from one account in the past, so it is clear that there is no independence in the sources used to confirm the validity of statements.

2.3 Salt within Regional Commodity Circuits

A region’s involvement with salt production was contingent on the flows connecting the supply of the commodity to demand. A productive area might have been located far from the consumers of its produce while the transporters of salt needed sustenance, livestock and access to trading partners. Salt therefore became involved in transactions going beyond itself alone. Following these arrangements reveals how production and circulation interacted: the return from a journey might take the form of grain, money or other goods needed to sustain the household and prepare another journey.

Walton’s description illustrates an early twentieth century example. Trading through Mana and Niti involved the use of passes which opened and closed according to the seasons when the snow thawed. Transport took place largely on sheep and goats as well as other pack animals. During the period when passage was possible, some traders were able to make a number of trips (Walton, 1910, p. 42). This created the route as a repeated activity rather than a constant

path. There was dependence on being able to coordinate departure, transport and return within a particular period of time.

The animals were central to this coordination. Walton explains that their need for enough grazing time reduced their speed in terms of daily distance traveled (Walton, 1910, p. 45). Transport capacity was therefore connected to pastoral management. Increasing the length or frequency of a journey could not be considered solely in terms of a merchant's willingness to travel. This helps explain why the geographical distance between markets is insufficient for reconstructing the practical organisation of a trading circuit.

The goods moving through these routes were varied. Salt and borax are identified as imports and grain as being among the primary exports along with wool, cloth and many other items (Walton, 1910, p. 44). Salt and borax were usually bartered with grain, but others involved either money or piece goods. Different modes of payments were possible in the same situation. Thus, barter cannot be regarded as a sign of the absence of calculation in the economic life of the area, while money cannot be seen as a sign of the end of social obligations organising the exchange.

The trading partnership provides a more precise view of those obligations. Each Bhotia trader, in Walton's account, had a recognised Tibetan correspondent or mitra.In the Niti valley the partners should have engaged in trade with each other and violation could result in punishment (Walton, 1910, p. 44). Partnership brought together the chance of trading and the long-term relationship. It could create a mode of exchange while limiting the choice of partners. What is historically important about this is the connection of access and obligation, not equality and freedom of the customary relations.

Frontier traders were not the only people involved in salt's onward movement. Walton describes villagers obtaining or borrowing flocks to trade between the passes and their own neighbourhoods. Salt received for grain was then distributed through upper Garhwal (Walton, 1910, p. 44). This is because it is possible for those who do not have access to Tibet to associate imports from the highlands with local consumers. Additionally, there is one practical criterion of participation, which can mean that the trader may need access to pack animals regardless of whether he owns the flock or not.

Another stage began during the winter season. The merchandise was headed in the south, with temporary camps and stores set up on the way. The merchandise was sold in the neighbouring villages and whatever was left could be sold in Kotdwara or Ramnagar. Further journeys were sometimes necessary to dispose of stocks left behind (Walton, 1910, pp. 44–45). Storage is thus a feature of circulation, not a break in it. The merchandise was sometimes split and sold at two different times, which made the process of circulation more complicated than a simple transportation from a Tibetan market to a plains town.

The same account records the carriage of grain or plains salt uphill on return journeys (Walton, 1910, p. 44). The direction was not determined by a theoretical dichotomy between the mountain producers and the lowland consumers. The traders participated in several streams of

supply and a trail used for transporting Tibetan salt could also serve for importing an alternative product. A commercial corridor might remain active while the origin or composition of its goods changed.

Rupshu introduces an important chronological variation. Ahmed places the turn towards Tso Kar as a major salt source after the disruption of access to Tibet in the early 1960s. Earlier journeys obtained salt from Tibetan lakes for onward exchange, including exchange for barley in Zanskar (Ahmed, 1999, pp. 32–33). Tso Kar should therefore be examined within a history of changing supply rather than presented as the unchanged origin of every Rupshu salt circuit. Continuity in trading activity could coexist with a substantial alteration in where the traded commodity was obtained.

The Kanum survey brings household participation into sharper focus. In its account of the 1964 revisit, it reports that only ten or twelve of the village's 113 families had engaged in trade with Tibet. Their exchanges included salt, wool, pashm, livestock and food products, with Rampur serving as a place of purchase and subsequent sale (Singh, 1966a, p. 113). Direct involvement in such trade was the preserve of a minority, but the impact of foreign goods and business activities might have reached beyond these few families.

Capital access can provide a good answer to the above question. The survey associates business with families having assets and even occasional borrowing from moneylenders or trading goods on credit from Rampur merchants. Credit from the latter could carry an obligation to sell to them after returning (Singh, 1966a, p. 113). A trader's itinerary was thus connected to financial commitments as well as physical routes. Commercial dependence could arise through credit even when the journey itself was undertaken by the borrower.

Lal Chand Negi's case gives this arrangement a seasonal and occupational setting. The survey describes his journeys during the 1940s, with departure in July and return to Kanum usually by November. He used to travel with animals, and also employed shepherds, exchanging various types of goods ranging from food stuffs to textiles and utensils for wool and salt. Later the commodities were sent to Rampur (Singh, 1966a, p. 114). This clearly shows a well-planned business venture in terms of transport, labour, and exchange process. The trader household was neither an individual traveler with surplus goods nor a separate merchant.

The shepherds' remuneration included provisions and goods as well as money, according to the survey's description of Lal Chand's caravan (Singh, 1966a, p. 114). Their work made the trading expedition possible, but their role was not the same as that of the person who financed and coordinated the effort. To consider everyone traveling together as one kind of trader would be to overlook this point. The circuit linked people by different roles and gains, so the organisation of labour became part of commodity history and not an external context.

Lavi at Rampur combined journeys such as this one with the concentrated market place. According to the Census description, the fair takes place in November and is linked with the arrival of the shepherds from higher pastures and with wool to sell (Singh, 1967, p. 189). Thus, the significance of the fair depended on the calendar as well as on the location. This

concentration of activities accounts for how dispersed production could make a large market possible without having producers live close to the trading center.

The description of the fair that took place between 11-13 November 1962 includes wool and pashmina traders, livestock merchants, shops and small traders. It also describes participants selling a few woollen articles to obtain household requirements and, in some cases, purchasing wool for further production (Singh, 1967, pp. 190–192). Both kinds of exchanges took place within the same gathering but had their respective functions. Thus, the market combined commercial exchange and the household provision with the revival of productive activity.

In this way, this evidence creates the framework of the wider market context for the trade involving salt but not reducing the fair transaction to a transaction on salt. Kanum's survey provides information about imports from Tibet including salt and sales of these commodities in Rampur; the description of the fair helps us understand the variety of the market that received these trips. Taken together, they can be seen as the evidence of the history of intersecting commodity flows. They do not establish that wool, grain and all other goods depended equally upon salt. That stronger proposition requires comparison of the connections sustained by different commodities, including the people and places they shared.

Lavi provided some information as well. According to the Nachar survey, the seasonal migration and visits to the fair were the moments when people could get the news from other places (Singh, 1966b, p. 54). It means that the importance of the fair transcends the scope of recorded purchases and does not reduce all social contacts to economic motives. Trade created the grounds for the meeting while purposes and results of these meetings could go far beyond the initial transaction.

The mid-century evidence also shows that circulation was being reorganised. The Kanum revisits reveal that the change in Makhan Lal Negi from Tibetan trade to roadside foodstall and shop commenced in 1959. Although his trade benefited from the road, the change in traffic alignment necessitated yet another change in the location of the business, which included setting up an establishment near Spillo (Singh, 1966a, pp. 113–114). Hence, the effect of the road was not the same at all locations as it reallocated traffic from one route to another.

On the other hand, Lal Chand's change took place in 1947 when he found the returns from the Tibetan trade insufficient in relation to the efforts that it required, before moving into panchayat employment. Padam Ram, by contrast, reported adverse effects from the closure of trade despite having other financial resources (Singh, 1966a, p. 114). These cases resist a single chronology in which all traders prospered until an identical external shock forced them out. Withdrawal, diversification and continued dependence occurred at different times. The effect of disruption was mediated by land, capital, employment and earlier occupational decisions.

Thus, the lesson learned for the study of commodity history is that the changing conditions of trade and the changing nature of occupation need to be analysed together and not interchangeably. A household may stop transporting the Tibetan salt but still be engaged in commercial activities. Similarly, a village may have lost passing trade while gaining wage labour

as occupation. Such changes can be identified by the primary source material and provide the context for the analysis of regulation of trade.

2.4 Commodity Regulation and Frontier Authority

Political authority entered salt circulation at several points. It could regulate entry into a territory, recognise exclusive trading privileges, supervise extraction or claim a share of revenue. These interventions did not necessarily belong to one institution. A trader might encounter different authorities while obtaining goods, crossing a pass and selling a consignment. Understanding the political economy of salt therefore requires attention to the location and object of each claim: control over production was different from authority over transit, and both differed from the power to determine an authorised price.

The Tingmosgang Treaty offers a previous example of commercial dealings incorporated within interactions of authorities. Its reproduced clauses address wool privileges, recognised traders, tea and periodic missions (Tibet Justice Center, n.d., clauses 2–5). Salt is not mentioned directly in these clauses. The treaty is significant in our context as it represents the organised arrangement of selective commodity flow, rather than something that can be taken as direct evidence of salt monopoly. It establishes a political context whose application to salt must be demonstrated separately.

It is the account of Walton that makes the trade in Garhwal specific. Permission was granted after investigating conditions regarding disease in people and animals before any trader from Niti passed into Tibet. Further licences allowed trade at additional marts (Walton, 1910, pp. 42–43). Permission thus was not just crossing a border but was tied with inspection, payment, and recognition by the authority. The existence of a route did not give every person an equivalent entitlement to use it or to trade at every destination.

Regulation was also variable between different groups. Walton notes the different responsibilities and rights of traders who were associated with Niti and Mana, as well as the rights that impacted competition in salt and wool (Walton, 1910, p. 43). In this way, regulation was a part of the history of access to trade. A trader could profit from the regulations put upon his competitor while himself paying considerable fees. Regulation can thus not be understood as something external to the differentiated community of traders. It could be used to give them different advantages.

Licensing, monopoly and taxation should remain distinguishable in this account. A licence gives certain permissions; a monopoly reserves an action or a market; a tax demands money. The mechanisms can interact, but one does not automatically establish the others. The Garhwal data also indicates why regulation cannot be considered to be solely a product of colonialism. Tibetan officials had control over the transactions described in the British gazetteer. The frontier economy was an economy of overlapping political relations even if it was described in the context of a colonial district.

Mandi reveals a different connection between salt and government. Here the political question centred partly on production within the state and its relationship with British revenue interests. The gazetteer records the cancellation of a contractor's arrangement on 1 July 1915, followed by direct state management of the quarries. It attributes the intervention to unsatisfactory working, including misuse of begar labour and delays in supplying traders (Emerson, 1920, p. 160). Problems at extraction thus affected circulation before a consignment left the production site. Administrative control of supply could influence a trader's time and capacity to undertake further exchange.

The account associates the revised management with reopening Guman and reorganising work. It describes paid labour replacing the earlier begar arrangement for the work under discussion, while also recording the importance of preparing the sources during the rains (Emerson, 1920, p. 160). Seasonality operated at the quarry as well as on the mountain pass. The availability and organisation of labour during one period affected supply during another. Production history thus adds another dimension which a route history would miss: the way salt became available for transportation.

The quarry establishment divided responsibilities among supervision, attendance, tools and weighing. Bonus payments according to sales performance were paid to workers, as well as local rituals and practices related to the quarry goddesses (Emerson, 1920, p. 161). The structure incorporated administration with practices known in the region. It cannot be reduced to a complete substitution of bureaucracy for custom. More revealing are the particular changes in who recorded work, who supervised it and how remuneration was organised. These facts place power of political and managerial nature in the production process.

There is an element of exception in terms of labour in the report of the gazetteer. Despite the fact that the abolition of begar is mentioned in connection with the quarrying labour, in other places it is noted that those carrying salt in head loads had to do one day's free work (Emerson, 1920, pp. 160, 163-164). These were different obligations attached to different positions. Their coexistence means that a general statement about abolition cannot be extended automatically to every person encountering the salt establishment.

Fiscal history also shows the link between Mandi production and British interests. In 1871 the additional duty was levied, whereby the receipts from salt sold to British territory were payable to the British Government. The officials of quarries had consignment destinations recorded in order to make distribution (Emerson, 1920, pp. 161-162). The destination register was consequently an instrument of government as well as a potential historical source. What it recorded followed from the administrative purpose for which it was created.

This friction led to a new division of responsibilities in 1880, with later provisions tying Mandi's duty to the British duty and restricting decreases in its price without the permission of Britain (Emerson, 1920, p. 162). This power was diffused rather than transferred through a simple transfer of ownership. The Raja had an interest in production and revenue, while British fiscal policy dictated the conditions under which salt could be sold. This is another example of the workings of colonialism in agreements about the commodity within a princely state.

These alterations in revenue collection practices did not mean the end of this relationship. As recorded in the gazetteer, there were reductions in the duty in 1903, 1905 and 1907, followed by an increase in 1916 (Emerson, 1920, pp. 163–164). These alterations mean that it should not be assumed that the level of taxation was constant in the period covered by the source. The price paid in production was related to decisions made by multiple authorities.

Further frontier regulations affected a completely different set of relationships. The Kinnaur gazetteer attributes the ending of trade with Tibet to restrictions on transactions, currency difficulties and the non-renewal of the trade agreement. It also highlights the problem of access to grazing land in Tibet and efforts made to channel the former traders into other pursuits (Mamgain, 1971, pp. 184–185). The consequences went beyond the transfer of commodities. Access to the pasture lands and transportation by means of the pack animals became part of the same political transformation, thus making the border significant for a number of livelihood factors.

Ahmed's case study of Rupshu offers an interesting contrast in that the disruption of border caused salt production locally, and roads as well as subsidised goods facilitated the shift from previous trading practices (Ahmed, 1999, p. 36). A convincing historical explanation needs to make clear whether there is a loss of access to a resource, a decline in the demand for travel, and alternative sources of supply.

The fair account offers a contemporary indication of disruption. Its observers noted that in November 1962, there were fewer attendees and trading transactions taking place at Lavi, attributing this to the situation along the border (Singh, 1967, p. 192). This is the case of an affected market during a particular period, as opposed to an indication of overall commercial decline within the region. In contrast to the family accounts, it represents political transformation at different levels, including the circumstances of a gathering, the feasibility of travel and the options open to individual traders.

Overall, these instances indicate that there is an element of authority embedded in the material practices of movement, work, and earnings. In addition, such an understanding highlights why a simple narrative of colonial rule followed by postcolonial closure would fall short. Commercial licences might shield some of the traders, production changes might sustain the status quo, and transportation routes could alter the course of economic activities after the decrease in the amount of frontier trading. In other words, the political importance of the salt was dependent on these relationships combined together.

2.5 From Dispersed Sources to Historical Networks

The above analysis shows connections that cannot be found in any one source. The gazetteer shows the geographical facts about the import business, while the village report has facts about the individual involved, the credit terms and the market afterwards. The problem here is a relational one since the evidence which needs to be used is one that connects various events and people through different sources.

This is where the historical network comes in. It can distinguish production from carriage, exchange from taxation, and a commercial partnership from a territorial claim. Combining all of them under a general category of association would lose the difference between a trader obtaining salt, an official charging a duty and a household receiving grain. The objective of reconstruction is to bring out these relations without losing the evidence passages themselves.

There are several requirements stemming from the documentary evidence. First, names should be standardised across different spellings; second, the date of the reported event must be distinguished from the date of its publication. A route described for one period should not be joined automatically to a later arrangement at the same place. Passages copied in different publications should also be distinguished from independent statements. This is necessary for historical comparison rather than for computational purposes alone.

The advantage of computing is in helping make this comparison through a greater amount of text. It can help organise references to commodities, places and institutions, bringing dispersed passages into a form that can be searched and examined together. A close reading is still required in order to determine the significance of any connection and whether the passage used to support it deserves that connection. The resulting representation should allow the researcher to return from an apparent pattern to the evidence on which it rests.

For this thesis, the historical question concerns the extent to which salt connected activities also involve other commodities. The information provided above highlights some potential connections based on common transport routes, trading partners, seasonal markets, and administrative links. What follows next is to compare these connections systematically and not to rely on the significance of the structure based on the appearance of the word salt. The next chapter outlines the approach for carrying out the comparison, which includes the use of Actor-Network Theory, along with other methods for creating documentary links.

2.6 Conclusion

This western Himalayan salt economy has been constructed out of networks encompassing the production, transport, exchange and regulation of the commodity. Seasonal migration in Garhwal, trade families in Kanum, the gathering at Lavi and rock salt quarry management in Mandi provide examples of each of these components of the system. A comparison between them highlights how a commodity could link different lives and jurisdictions while moving along with other products. This also demonstrates the existence of considerable diversity in terms of access, responsibilities and impact of change.

These factors become more explicit from the information available for the twentieth century. Availability of alternative sources, road construction, choice of occupations and frontier limitations could affect the routes in their own ways. The disappearance of one type of trade does not necessarily imply the absence of commerce, whereas the continuity of salt mining does not mean the continuation of its earlier routes.

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